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Short Writing Assignment #3
Psychology of Negotiation

"You're Just as Self Interested as I Am"

Gelfand and Christakopoulou's paper examined how cultural values shape negotiator cognition and judgment biases by conducting a two-week intercultural negotiation experiment between American (individualistic) and Greek (collectivistic) students over email. The study found that Americans exhibited a stronger "fixed pie" bias—misjudging their Greek counterparts' interests—whereas Greeks had more accurate assessments of their partners. Furthermore, despite achieving similar objective negotiation results, Greek participants were less satisfied with the negotiation outcome because they believed their counterparts neglected their priorities. The results suggested that individualistic cultures foster self-focused negotiation strategies, while collectivistic cultures encourage consideration of others' interests, ultimately influencing negotiation processes and outcomes. While this study effectively demonstrates that cultural differences can change the perception of negotiation outcomes for each negotiator, the study's conclusion is culturally biased because it applies an American-centric framework of negotiation success; because the study uses fixed pie judgment, an American-developed concept, as a key metric, it unfairly characterizes Greek negotiators as less self-interested.

If we consider the goals of each party, we see that for American's their desired outcome was to maximize individual gains (points) and for the Greeks an important aspect of the outcome was mutual understanding, cooperation, and feeling as though the other side understood their priorities. These are seemingly very incompatible values and it makes sense that when American's maximized their individual gains they ignored the priorities of Greek's more than Greek's ignored American priorities. I would expect that if a Greek negotiator were to negotiate with another Greek person and achieve the same objective outcomes that were achieved in this experiment, they would report being more satisfied with the outcome, since it is more likely that mutual understanding was reached. I would claim that Greek negotiators were just as self-serving in their satisfaction reports since they evaluated their success on their own culturally based negotiation standards. Essentially, both cultures have different standards of success in this experiment, so using fixed pie judgement, a judgement developed at Harvard by an American

academic, undoubtedly centered on American business) as a metric seems like a flawed approach (or at least an approach in which the outcome was quite predictable); they asked a Greek negotiator, who is seeking mutual understanding, to report the success of a negotiation with a negotiator that primarily sought individual gain. The Greek negotiators were essentially participating in a one-sided negotiation, from their cultural perspective.

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